

rules—like no one neglecting their yard or stuffing the street full of dangerously parked vehicles—make sure to tell your agent.

What features are an absolute must?

Make a list of the things you can't live without, such as a big kitchen, garage space, a good school district, and so on.

What features are complete deal breakers?

Likewise, make sure you write down anything you can't live *with*, like a high-maintenance backyard or being adjacent to a busy street.

Knowing the answer to each of these questions will give you a clear idea of what you want. That way you'll be able to keep your eyes on the prize when you start looking at properties in person. You'll also be able to communicate your needs to a lender and a real estate agent. Here's a great example:

I would like a two-bedroom, two-bathroom home in Denver, Colorado, in the neighborhoods of Sloan's Lake, the Highlands, Capitol Hill, or River North. I'm looking for a property priced at \$400,000 or less. My home must have a solid master bedroom with a closet, an open kitchen, and a two-car garage, but I'm not interested in anything within an HOA community, on a busy street, within five blocks of a high school, or next door to a commercial property. I will also pay more for properties that have easy access to features like parks or restaurants, and I'll pay less for areas closer to major thoroughfares or industrial buildings. I'm willing to take on a house that needs new paint, landscaping, and bathroom updates but nothing more involved than that. I understand my target neighborhoods reasonably well, and five to ten properties that more or less meet my criteria appear to have sold in the last 180 days.

This buyer is not living in fantasyland, since similar properties have *sold* in the last six months—note the emphasis on “sold.” This is absolutely critical, and here's why.